Vivienne Zhang

vzhang2@uchicago.edu +1 (312) 989 7629

Education

The University of Chicago 2023 - 2027
B.A. in Linguistics, Minor in Computer Science GPA: 4.0/4.0
Robert Maynard Hutchins Scholar, 2025
Phi Beta Kappa
Georgiana Simpson Scholar in the Humanities Collegiate Division, 2026

St. Catherine's College, the University of Oxford Oct - Dec 2025

Research Experience

BA Honours Thesis – **Felicity Conditions on Projected Responses as a Basis for Relevance of Non-Answering Replies to Polar Questions** Aug 2026 - present
(Thesis advisor: Prof. Chris Kennedy)
▪ Developing a formal account of why uninformative replies regarding the questioned proposition are judged relevant by modelling relevance as a reply's bearing on the felicity conditions of the response a question projects, in addition to its bearing on the questioned proposition; extending the account to directives and other response types

Independent Researcher – **Mechanistic Analysis of LLM Commissive Sensitivity** June 2026 - present
(Supervisor: Dr. Zhewei Sun, Toyota Technological Institute at Chicago)
▪ Proposed & investigating how language models respond to commissive speech acts and how to mechanistically steer the strength of their reaction
▪ Conducted literature review and ran pilot experiments using the Cornell Movie Dialog corpus

Research Collaborator – **LLM Persona Collapse and Homogenization** Oct 2025 - April 2026
▪ Originated and proposed the project, leading to research group formation
▪ Led initial literature review and built the prototype pipeline; contributed to test dataset construction
▪ Co-first-authored resulting paper (Yunze Xiao†, Vivienne J. Zhang†, Chenghao Yang, Ningshan Ma, Weihao Xuan, Jen-tse Huang; preprint), proposing a geometric framework to quantify population diversity of simulated personas (†: equal contribution)
▪ Accepted at UserSim @ NeurIPS 2026

Co-Investigator – **Dajing Dialect Documentation** June - Dec 2025 (on hiatus)
(Seidel Scholar Grant; PI: Prof. Lenore Grenoble)
▪ Conducted 4 weeks of fieldwork in Yueqing, China; transcribed and translated speech data from 11 speakers; produced a meta-documentation
▪ Built a public-facing website presenting translated recordings, cultural texts, and a lexicon

Research Assistant – **Second Language Acquisition Group, McGill University** June - Sep 2025
(Director: Prof. Heather Goad, Prof. Lydia White)

▪ Reviewed literature on German noun plural morphology & prosody; presented findings in lab meetings
▪ Contributed to hypothesis development and experimental design for a study on prosodic transfer in L2 German learners (English/Mandarin L1)

Research Assistant – **The Phonology Laboratory, UChicago** July 2023 - May 2025
(Director: Prof. Alan C. L. Yu)
▪ Designed an experiment testing effects of lexical neighborhood density on phonetic perception
▪ Implemented an experiment examining cue weighting in perception and production
▪ Ran participants through an EEG study protocol
▪ Verified and corrected forced aligned VOT and sonorant duration measurements in Praat
▪ Helped construct the corpus presented at CorpusPhon, 2024 ("The Multi-ethnic Hong Kong Cantonese Corpus for the Study of Child-Directed Speech")

Presentations

"The Chameleon's Limit: Investigating Persona Collapse and Homogenization in Large Language Models". Poster presented at UChicago Undergraduate Research Symposium, 2026.

Term papers

▪ "Sycophancy Toward Delusional Content in Large Language Models: Effects of User Vulnerability" (2026, individual project) – examined whether knowledge of a user's psychiatric vulnerability modulates sycophantic behaviour
▪ "FELICITYBENCH: Pragmatic (In)felicity Sensitivity in LLMs" (2025, team project) – investigated LLMs' comprehension of felicity conditions and behavioural response to infelicitous utterances

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Skills

▪ Languages: Mandarin (native); English & French (fluent)
▪ Praat, ELAN; familiarity with FLEx and Python; experiment design in Qualtrics and Gorilla
▪ LLM-as-judge evaluation pipelines, familiarity with model serving via vLLM/HuggingFace